

London's Secret Gardens

10 Hidden Green Spaces · All Free · Central London

Beyond the famous parks, London hides extraordinary secret gardens — from physic gardens to walled Tudor retreats. All free, most unknown to tourists, and each with its own story.

YOU SAVE: £140 vs guided tours

■ WHAT THIS GUIDE SAVES YOU

Retail price of this guide
£9.99

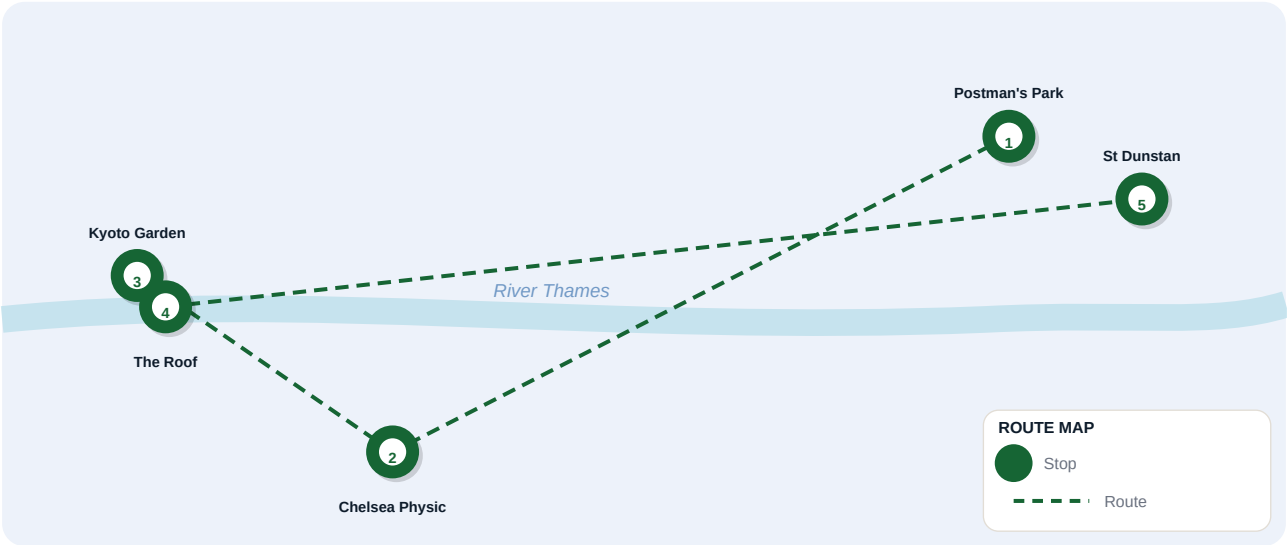
Equivalent guided tours
£150

YOUR SAVING
£140

ROUTE INFO

■ Start	Postman's Park — Watts Memorial (City of London)
■ End	St Dunstan in the East Garden (City of London)
■ Duration	All Free
■ Transport	From central London: Zone 1–2 daily cap £8.10 covers all stops
■ Total Cost	Guide: £9.99 · Most stops FREE · See individual stop costs

SCHEMATIC ROUTE MAP



PRO TIPS — READ BEFORE YOU GO

■ Best day	Tuesday–Thursday for fewer crowds at almost every location
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■ Saving	Pre-book anything with tickets — usually £2–4 discount per person
■ Offline map	Download Google Maps offline before leaving your hotel
■ Transport	Use Contactless card — automatic daily cap (Zone 1: £8.10, Zone 1-2: £10.10)
■ Members only	This guide is exclusive to London Lens lifetime subscribers

■ COMPLETE STOP GUIDE — LONDON'S SECRET GARDENS

Follow stops 1→5 in order for the best walking route. Each card includes insider tips, savings info, and the cheapest transport option.

1

Postman's Park — Watts Memorial

City of London · Daily 8am–dusk

■ START HERE

HIDDEN TIP

A hidden garden containing the Watts Memorial to Heroic Self-Sacrifice — a Victorian wall of ceramic tiles, each commemorating an ordinary person who died saving someone else. Featured in the film Closer. Profoundly moving and completely unknown.

■ SAVING

Free. Garden 'experience' tours charge £12. Saving: £12

■ CHEAPEST TRANSPORT

St Paul's (5 min walk)
Cost: Zone 1

DO THIS:

- ✓ Read every tile on the Watts Memorial
- ✓ Find the tile for the oldest commemorated hero
- ✓ The garden has benches — bring a picnic

■ Best: Lunchtime on a weekday when City workers briefly appear

AVOID:

Nothing — always peaceful

★★★★★

Free

2

Chelsea Physic Garden

Chelsea · Feb–Oct, Tue–Fri & Sun 11am–6pm

■ 30 min or tube

HIDDEN TIP

Founded in 1673 — older than Kew. The walled garden that supplied plant specimens to Hans Sloane (who founded the British Museum). The first cotton seeds sent to Georgia, USA, came from this garden. Extraordinary history in a tiny secret space.

■ SAVING

Free with Art Fund card (£67/year saves hundreds). On its own: £14 is worth it

■ CHEAPEST TRANSPORT

Sloane Square (10 min walk)
Cost: Zone 1

DO THIS:

- ✓ Find the North American Order Bed — cotton history
- ✓ The pharmaceutical garden section
- ✓ Ask a gardener — they're extraordinarily knowledgeable

■ Best: Spring for herb garden · Summer for the pond

AVOID:

Winter — garden less impressive

★★★★★

£14 adults

3



Kyoto Garden — Holland Park

Holland Park · Daily 7:30am–30 min before dusk

■ 25 min or tube

HIDDEN TIP

A gift from the city of Kyoto in 1991. Waterfalls, koi carp, peacocks wandering freely, a stone lantern. Hidden in the middle of Holland Park. The peacocks routinely perch on the gate posts and look magnificent.

■ SAVING

Comparable Japanese gardens in Europe charge €8–15. Free here. Saving: £12

■ CHEAPEST TRANSPORT

Holland Park (8 min walk)
Cost: Zone 2

DO THIS:

- ✓ Watch the peacocks display at 9–10am
- ✓ The waterfall from above and below
- ✓ Find the stone lantern donated by Kyoto City
- Best: Spring for cherry blossom · Early morning for peacocks

AVOID:

Rainy days (though atmospheric)

★★★★★

Free

4



The Roof Garden — Kensington

Kensington · Mon–Fri when not private events — check virginlimitededition.com

■ 15 min from Holland Park

HIDDEN TIP

1.5 acres of garden on the 6th floor of a former Derry & Toms department store. Flamingos, Tudor garden, Spanish garden — 30 metres above Kensington High Street. Access is free when not used for private events — check the website.

■ SAVING

Rooftop bars nearby charge £20+ for entry. Free here when open. Saving: £20

■ CHEAPEST TRANSPORT

High Street Kensington (3 min walk)
Cost: Zone 2

DO THIS:

- ✓ Feed the flamingos if accessible
- ✓ The Tudor garden section — extraordinary
- ✓ Views over Kensington and London
- Best: Weekday mornings when fewer events scheduled

AVOID:

Not checking if it's open before visiting — private events block access...

★★★★■

Free when open



St Dunstan in the East Garden

City of London · Daily dawn to dusk

■ 30 min or tube

HIDDEN TIP

A Wren church tower with Blitz-bombed ruins converted into a public garden, draped entirely in wisteria and ivy. The Gothic window arches now frame pure sky. Spring wisteria is extraordinary. Autumn golden leaves are equally beautiful.

■ SAVING

Free. Unique experience equivalent tours charge £15. Saving: £15

■ CHEAPEST TRANSPORT

Monument (5 min walk)
Cost: Zone 1

DO THIS:

- ✓ Sit inside the ruined nave (benches provided)
 - ✓ Photograph the Gothic window arches against sky
 - ✓ The climbing plants change every season — worth multiple visits
- Best: April-May for wisteria · October for autumn colour

AVOID:

Nothing — perfect any time of year

★★★★★

Free

QUICK REFERENCE CARD — CUT OUT OR SCREENSHOT

Summary of all stops for easy on-the-go reference.

#	Name	Area	Walk	Cost	Tube	Rating
1	Postman's Park — Watts...	City of London	Start here	Free	St Paul's (5 min w	★★★★★
2	Chelsea Physic Garden	Chelsea	30 min or tube	£14 adults	Sloane Square (10	★★★★★
3	Kyoto Garden — Holland...	Holland Park	25 min or tube	Free	Holland Park (8 mi	★★★★★
4	The Roof Garden — Kens...	Kensington	15 min from Ho	Free when	High Street Kensin	★★★★■
5	St Dunstan in the East...	City of London	30 min or tube	Free	Monument (5 min wa	★★★★★

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